AERION DAW

BY AETHOS STUDIO

DIGITAL AUDIO WORKSTATION

PRE-ALPHA · v0.0.1

USER MANUAL

Getting Started Guide

Release Date: May 2026 | Platform: Windows 10 / 11 (x64)

Aethos Studio Ltd. · aethos.studio

Licensed under the GNU General Public License v3.0

Contents

1 Introduction 3

2 System Requirements 3

3 Installation 4

4 Interface Overview 4

4.1 Menu Bar & Toolbar 5

4.2 Timeline 5

4.3 Mixer Panel 5

4.4 Browser 5

5 Feature Guide 6

5.1 Transport & Playback 6

5.2 Audio Tracks & Clips 6

5.3 MIDI Tracks & Piano Roll 7

5.4 Folder Tracks 7

5.5 Snap, Loop & Markers 8

5.6 Mixer & Channel Strip 8

5.7 Plugin Hosting (VST3) 8

5.8 Browser Panel 9

6 Known Limitations 9

7 License 10

© 2026 Aethos Studio Ltd. — GPL v3

01 —

Introduction

Aerion DAW is a modern, cross-platform Digital Audio Workstation developed by Aethos Studio Ltd. Built on the Tracktion Engine (v3.2) and JUCE 8 framework, Aerion is designed for musicians, producers, and sound designers who want a clean, precise editing environment with first-class VST3 plugin support.

This document covers **v0.0.1 Pre-Alpha** — the first publicly available build, released in May 2026. This is an early feedback release. Core editing, MIDI sequencing, and plugin hosting are functional; several workflow features (project save/load, audio export) are still in development.

! This is a pre-alpha release intended for peer feedback and early testing only. Do not use this build for any production work — it does not yet support saving or exporting projects.

02 —

System Requirements

COMPONENT	MINIMUM	RECOMMENDED
Operating System	Windows 10 (64-bit)	Windows 11 (64-bit)
CPU	Intel Core i5 / AMD Ryzen 5	Intel Core i7 / AMD Ryzen 7 or better
RAM	8 GB	16 GB or more
Storage	500 MB free disk space	SSD with 2 GB+ free
Audio	Any WASAPI-compatible device	ASIO-capable audio interface
Display	1280 x 720	1920 x 1080 or higher
Plugins	—	64-bit VST3 plugins

i High-DPI scaling support is planned for a future release. On 4K displays, the UI may appear small at 100% scaling. Use Windows display scaling at 150-200% as a workaround.

© 2026 Aethos Studio Ltd. — GPL v3

03 —

Installation

1. **Download** `Aerion-DAW-Setup-0.0.1.exe` from the GitHub release page at `github.com/aethos-studio/Aerion-DAW/releases/tag/v0.0.1-alpha`
2. **Run the installer.** If Windows SmartScreen appears, click "More info" then "Run anyway". (The binary is unsigned in this pre-alpha build.)
3. **Follow the setup wizard.** Accept the default installation path (`C:\Program Files\Aerion DAW\`) or choose a custom location.
4. **Choose shortcut options.** The installer can place a shortcut on the Desktop and in the Start Menu.
5. **Click Install**, then **Finish**. Aerion DAW launches automatically.

> i To uninstall, use Windows Settings → Apps → Aerion DAW → Uninstall, or run the uninstaller from the Start Menu folder.

04 —

Interface Overview

The Aerion DAW window is divided into five main regions:

```
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
|  MENU BAR   File - Edit - Song - Track - Event - Audio - View |
+--------------+----------------------------------------------+
|              |  TOOLBAR   Play  Stop  Rec  BPM  Time Sig  Snap|
|              +----------------------------------------------+
|   BROWSER    |                                               |
|              |              TIMELINE                        |
|  Files       |   Track headers + clip lanes + ruler         |
|  Plugins     |                                               |
|              +----------------------------------------------+
|              |              MIXER PANEL                     |
|              |   Channel strip per track (fader - pan - FX)  |
+--------------+----------------------------------------------+
```

4.1 MENU BAR & TOOLBAR

The **Menu Bar** at the top provides access to file operations, edit commands, track management, and view toggles. The **Toolbar** directly below contains the transport controls (Play, Stop, Record), the current playhead position, BPM and time signature fields, metronome toggle, and the snap interval selector.

4.2 TIMELINE

The central **Timeline** is where you arrange, record, and edit audio and MIDI clips. The ruler at the top shows beat/bar positions. Track headers on the left display each track's name, Mute, Solo, Record-arm, and Automation buttons, plus an FX badge. Scroll horizontally with the scrollbar at the bottom; zoom in/out with `Ctrl + Scroll`.

4.3 MIXER PANEL

The **Mixer Panel** at the bottom shows a channel strip for the currently selected track, including a volume fader with peak meter, pan control, and insert plugin slots. Toggle the mixer with `View → Mixer`.

4.4 BROWSER

The left-side **Browser** has two tabs — Files for navigating your audio library (with waveform preview on hover) and Plugins for discovering installed VST3 instruments and effects. Drag items directly onto the Timeline.

© 2026 Aethos Studio Ltd. — GPL v3

05 —

Feature Guide

5.1 TRANSPORT & PLAYBACK

PLAY / STOP

Click Play to start playback from the current playhead position. Click Stop to halt. Clicking Play again resumes from the same position.

RECORD

Arm a track with the **R** button in its header, then click Record. Audio is captured in real-time to the timeline.

BPM & TIME SIGNATURE

Click the BPM field and type a new value (or scroll). The Time Signature fields accept numerator / denominator independently.

METRONOME

Toggle the metronome click in the toolbar. The volume slider next to it controls click loudness independently of the master output.

5.2 AUDIO TRACKS & CLIPS

Importing Audio

Drag any `.wav`, `.aiff`, `.mp3`, `.ogg`, or `.flac` file from the Browser or from Windows Explorer directly onto an empty track lane. Aerion generates a waveform thumbnail automatically.

Alternatively, use Track → Add Audio Track from the Menu Bar to create a new track, then drag a file onto it.

Clip Editing

- → **Move** — Click and drag the body of a clip to reposition it along the timeline.
- → **Trim (start)** — Drag the left edge of a clip to change where it starts within the source audio.
- → **Trim (end)** — Drag the right edge to shorten or extend the clip's endpoint.
- → **Fade In** — Drag the small white dot at the top-left corner of the clip to create a fade-in envelope.
- → **Fade Out** — Drag the small white dot at the top-right corner to create a fade-out envelope.
- → **Split** — Select the Blade tool in the toolbar, then click anywhere on a clip to split it at that position.
- → **Right-click** — Opens a context menu with options to delete the clip, rename the track, or move the track into a folder.

> **i** When Snap is enabled, trim and move operations snap to the selected beat/bar grid. Hold `Alt` to temporarily bypass snap.

© 2026 Aethos Studio Ltd. — GPL v3

5.3 MIDI TRACKS & PIANO ROLL

Create a MIDI track via Track → Add MIDI Track. MIDI clips appear as coloured blocks in the timeline. Double-click any MIDI clip to open the **Piano Roll editor**.

Piano Roll

DRAWING NOTES

In **Pencil** mode, click on the piano roll grid to place a note. Drag horizontally to set its length.

SELECTING & MOVING

Switch to **Select** mode. Click to select a note; drag to move it in pitch or time. Shift-click to add to the selection.

VELOCITY

The velocity lane at the bottom shows per-note velocity bars. Click and drag to adjust individual velocities.

ZOOM & SCROLL

Scroll vertically to move through the keyboard range. Use the zoom slider or `Ctrl + Scroll` to zoom horizontally.

> **i** MIDI quantization and CC lane editing are planned for v0.1.0.

5.4 FOLDER TRACKS

Folder tracks group related audio and MIDI tracks together visually. Create one via Track → Add Folder Track. Drag existing tracks into the folder using the right-click context menu (Move to Folder...).

Click the **chevron** to the left of a folder track's name to collapse or expand its contents. Collapsed folders save vertical screen space without affecting playback.

> **i** Submix folders route all contained tracks through a shared output, enabling group processing with a single plugin chain.

5.5 SNAP, LOOP & MARKERS

Snap

Toggle snapping with the **Snap** button in the toolbar. The interval selector next to it sets the grid resolution (bar, beat, 1/2 beat, 1/4 beat, etc.). All clip edits and moves will snap to the selected grid when snap is active.

Loop Range

The loop range brackets are displayed on the ruler. Drag the **left bracket** to set the loop start and the **right bracket** to set the loop end. The transport will cycle within this range when looping is active.

Markers

Select the **Marker** tool from the toolbar, then click on the ruler to place a named marker. Markers are useful for navigating large sessions and for defining song sections.

5.6 MIXER & CHANNEL STRIP

VOLUME FADER

Drag vertically to set the track level. The peak meter shows real-time signal level and clips red if the signal exceeds 0 dBFS.

PAN KNOB

Drag left/right to pan the track in the stereo field. Double-click to reset to centre.

MUTE / SOLO

M mutes the track. **S** solos the track (all other non-soloed tracks are muted). Multiple tracks can be soloed simultaneously.

AUTOMATION

Click **A** on a track header to show its automation lane. Volume automation is displayed as an editable curve beneath the clips.

© 2026 Aethos Studio Ltd. — GPL v3

5.7 PLUGIN HOSTING (VST3)

Aerion DAW supports 64-bit VST3 plugins on Windows. To add a plugin to a track:

1. Click the **FX** button on any track header to open the Plugin Manager for that track.
2. In the Plugin Manager, click **+** or drag a plugin from the Browser's Plugins tab.
3. Double-click a plugin entry to open its editor window.
4. Use the plugin's own interface to adjust parameters. The window is hosted natively inside Aerion DAW.

> **i** VST3 plugins are scanned automatically on first launch. If a newly installed plugin does not appear, use Audio → Rescan Plugins from the Menu Bar.

> **!** Plugin preset browsing and per-plugin bypass are planned for v0.1.0. In this release, remove a plugin by right-clicking its entry in the Plugin Manager.

5.8 BROWSER PANEL

Files tab — Navigate your file system to find audio samples. Click a file to preview it with waveform display and playback. Drag a file onto any audio track to import it, or onto an empty area to create a new track automatically.

Plugins tab — Shows all scanned VST3 plugins grouped by manufacturer. Drag a plugin directly onto a track header to add it to that track's plugin chain.

06 —

Known Limitations (Pre-Alpha v0.0.1)

The following features are not yet implemented in this release and will be addressed in upcoming milestones:

- x **No audio export / mixdown** — There is currently no way to bounce or export audio.
- x **Mixer sends/routing work in progress** — Aux sends are partially implemented; behaviour may be unpredictable.
- x **No MIDI quantization** — Notes must be positioned manually in the Piano Roll.
- x **No tempo automation** — The BPM is fixed for the entire session.
- x **No keyboard shortcuts** — All operations are mouse-driven in this release.
- x **No crash recovery** — If the application crashes, unsaved work is lost.
- x **Binary is unsigned** — Windows SmartScreen will warn on first run. This will be resolved before the public beta.

07 —

License

Aerion DAW is free and open-source software licensed under the **GNU General Public License v3.0**.


```
Copyright (C) 2026  Aethos Studio Ltd.

This program is free software: you can redistribute it and/or modify
it under the terms of the GNU General Public License as published by
the Free Software Foundation, either version 3 of the License, or
(at your option) any later version.

This program is distributed in the hope that it will be useful,
but WITHOUT ANY WARRANTY; without even the implied warranty of
MERCHANTABILITY or FITNESS FOR A PARTICULAR PURPOSE. See the
GNU General Public License for more details.

You should have received a copy of the GNU General Public License
along with this program. If not, see <https://www.gnu.org/licenses/>.
```


The full license text is included as a `LICENSE` file in the release download and in the source repository at:

github.com/aethos-studio/Aerion-DAW

Third-party components (JUCE, Tracktion Engine) are used under their respective licenses. See the source repository for full attribution.